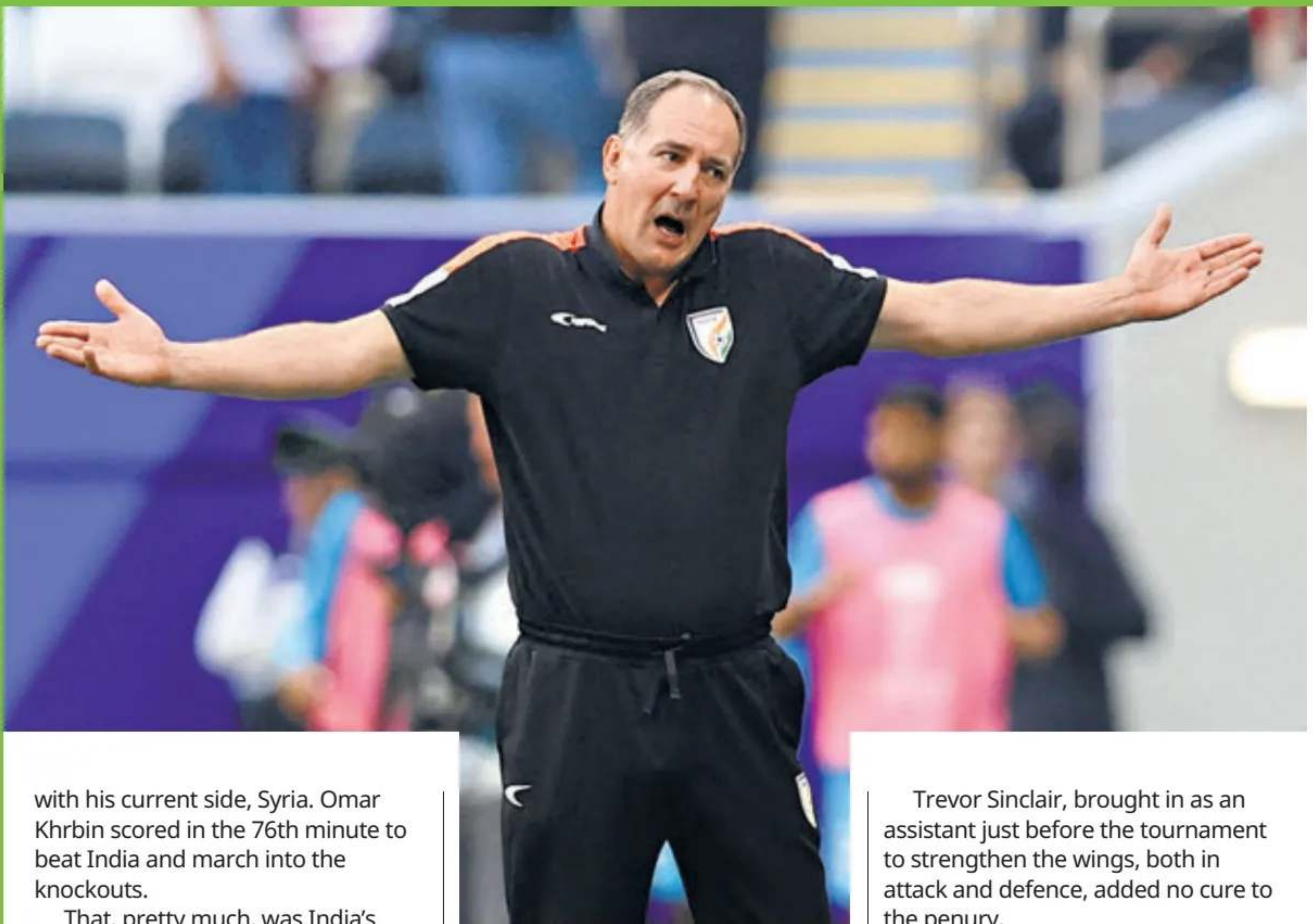




with his current side, Syria. Omar Khrbin scored in the 76th minute to beat India and march into the knockouts.

That, pretty much, was India's show — a pointless tour which ranks second from bottom in its all-time performances in the tournament. **Only the 2011 edition was worse for India, where it let in six more goals than in 2024 in the same country.**

Shortly after the tournament, Bob Houghton, the then-head coach of India, tendered his resignation.

Stimac, on the other hand, was handed a two-year contract extension before the tournament and awaits an extension of two years if his boys qualify for the third round of the FIFA World Cup qualifiers.

Outplayed in tactics and quality

In three games, India had six shots on target and allowed the opponents 18, an average of six shots on target per game. It not only showed its lack of clinical attack but also its porous defence.

It started its campaign without four injured first-team regulars: Ashique Kuruniyan (winger), Anwar Ali (centre-back), Jeakson Singh (defensive midfielder), and Sahal Abdul Samad (midfielder), with Sahal

Call for patience: "I don't have a magic sword. I'm a hardworking guy who is asking you to turn things around and be patient because good things in football do not happen overnight," Stimac said. REUTERS

only ready for the final game.

While this did weaken the team, it was here that the prowess of a coach should have come into play. "The structure of the game and tactics should not suffer from who acts as a performer," legendary coach Valery Lobanovsky once said.

Stimac remained the second-best coach in all matches his boys played, and that will be something the All India Football Federation (AIFF) will have to look into after this forgettable outing.

India looked especially outplayed along both flanks, where its first-team starters, Akash Mishra and Nikhil Poojary, were both fit and available. All of India's goals came with build-up through the wings, with three goals from either flank.

Trevor Sinclair, brought in as an assistant just before the tournament to strengthen the wings, both in attack and defence, added no cure to the penury.

Rahul Bheke, filling in for Anwar, could never step up as a ball-playing center-back — a role the latter thrived in, alongside Sandesh Jhingan.

In attack, Lallianzuala Chhangte was the only impressive player with his ubiquitous presence on the field. When the team had possession, he would march up the pitch to assist the offence and would track back soon after losing possession.

Chhetri (right) has been one of the best servants of Indian football, with 93 goals to his name, but at 39, this Asian Cup might have been his last appearance in the competition. He looked rusty throughout the campaign, and India will have to look at his replacement sooner rather than later.

In the midfield, Deepak Tangri came of age, impressing in his senior team debut, but Lalengmawia Ralte's lack of experience at the competitive level allowed the opponents to win the ball outside the penalty box, which saw Syria capitalise the most in its final match.